



126 Check Your TQ



127 Reviews of the Month



130 Stop Stealing Songs!

Digital Leisure

Technology Beyond Work

Meera Vankipuram

Following the death of her husband in a construction accident while working in Jeddah, Saudi Arabia, Kannatha, a resident of Uranganpatti village in Madurai district in Tamil Nadu, ran into financial problems.

She was advised to seek compensation from her husband's former employers, but had no clue how to go about it. She sought help from the local Internet kiosk operator, who not only located the e-mail address of the Indian Consulate in Jeddah, but also typed out an e-mail and sent it on her behalf.

Two weeks later, she received a parcel containing the relevant documents, which were duly filled and sent out. A month

after sending the original e-mail, Kannatha and her family received Rs 1.3 lakh in compensation—and all she spent was Rs 30 for a few hours of Internet access.

Thanks to SARI (Sustainable Access in Rural India), a pioneering project conceptualised by a professor from IIT-Madras, the Web now helps struggling farmers become successful entrepreneurs. The Web also gives people from villages across Tamil Nadu access to better medical facilities, higher education and solves agriculture-related problems, among other things.

The project, which draws on the research expertise of Harvard University Centre for International Development, IIT

Madras and the Massachusetts Institute of Technology's Media Lab, seeks to harness Information and

Communication Technologies (ICTs) to improve health, education and economic development in rural areas, by deploying innovative technologies and effective, economically sustainable, business models.

SARI is managed by the Telecommunications and Computer Networks Group (TeNeT), Department of Electrical Engineering, IIT Madras, led by Dr Ashok Jhunjhunwala.

It works in close association with the telecom and computer industry to develop ICTs such as the corDECT Wireless in Local Loop system, Fibre Access

Touched by Tech

The Global Village

In a world shrunk by technology, an obscure hamlet in the Madurai district of Tamil Nadu is showing the way to harness the power of the Internet



Photograph: Meera Vankipuram/Parag Joshi